TEACHER GUIDE | LESSON 13

2 Corinthians Part 1

Power in Weakness

BIG IDEA God displays Christ's power through weak, suffering servants who minister with integrity and reconciliation.

Purpose and outcome

By the end of the lesson, the class should be able to:

- explain how God's comfort equips suffering believers to comfort others;
- describe new covenant ministry as Spirit-given life and transformation rather than condemnation written only on stone;
- show how the treasure in jars of clay makes God's power visible through human weakness;
- connect resurrection hope and Christ's judgment seat with courage, faithfulness, and pleasing the Lord; and
- apply Christ's ministry of reconciliation and Paul's call to holiness without withdrawing from unbelieving neighbors.

Lesson at a glance

TIME	MOVEMENT
0:00-5:00	Opening question, prayer, and transition from 1 Corinthians
5:00-12:00	Comfort, integrity, and restoration - 1:3-2:13
12:00-23:00	New covenant ministry - 2:14-3:18
23:00-33:00	Treasure in jars of clay - 4:1-18
33:00-43:00	Resurrection hope and reconciliation - 5:1-6:13
43:00-48:00	Holiness and godly sorrow - 6:14-7:16
48:00-50:00	Summary, homework, and prayer

Before class

Write on the board: What makes a Christian ministry credible?

Controlling question: How does God display Christ's power through weak and suffering servants?

Mark 2 Corinthians 3:4-6, 12-18; 4:7-12, 16-18; 5:14-21; and 6:14-7:1. Use one reader and summarize the surrounding material so the class follows the argument rather than drowning in references.

PROTECT THE SPINE Required: the Spirit's new covenant ministry, treasure in jars of clay, and reconciliation in Christ. Summarize: Paul's painful relationship with Corinth, comfort in suffering, the intermediate state, and godly sorrow. Leader notes only unless asked: theories that 2 Corinthians combines several letters and detailed systems of reward at Christ's judgment seat. Safely omit: reconstructing every lost letter and visit or deciding whether each modern entertainment choice is an unequal yoke.

The whole lesson in one claim

Corinth valued impressive speakers, visible strength, and public credentials. Paul points instead to God-given sufficiency, Spirit-transformed lives, endurance through suffering, and reconciliation through Christ. The messenger is fragile so that the power is unmistakably God's.

CENTRAL LINE True ministry does not manufacture strength. It carries Christ's treasure in clay jars so that God's transforming and reconciling power can be seen.

Setting A strained relationship moving toward restoration

Paul founded the Corinthian church during his second missionary journey (Acts 18). After 1 Corinthians, he made a painful visit and wrote a severe letter with tears, probably carried by Titus. Titus later met Paul in Macedonia with encouraging news that most of the church had responded with repentance and renewed affection (2:1-4; 7:5-16). Paul writes chapters 1-7 from that mixture of relief, lingering hurt, and hope for full reconciliation.

Some scholars understand 2 Corinthians as a collection of several Pauline letters, often treating chapters 10-13 as an earlier severe letter. Others see one letter whose sharp change in tone addresses a remaining resistant minority. The class does not need to resolve the compositional debate. Teach the canonical letter as received and note that its emotional shifts fit a complicated pastoral relationship.

1. CORE Comfort integrity and restoration

In 1:3-11, comfort means more than feeling soothed. God strengthens and encourages his people in affliction, often without immediately removing the affliction. Those who receive God's comfort become able to enter another person's suffering with hope. Paul never romanticizes pain: he describes being burdened beyond his ability so that he learned to rely on the God who raises the dead.

Paul's changed travel plans had been used to accuse him of unreliability. He answers that his conduct was marked by holiness and sincerity, and that he delayed another visit to spare the church further pain (1:12-2:4). His plans changed; God's promises did not. Every promise of God finds its Yes in Christ. Christian integrity therefore includes truthful explanation, concern for another's good, and refusal to manipulate with spiritual authority.

The offender in 2:5-11 cannot be identified with certainty; he may have led the opposition during Paul's painful visit rather than being the man disciplined in 1 Corinthians 5. The principle is clearer than the identity. Discipline aims at repentance and restoration. Once sorrow has produced repentance, the church must forgive, comfort, and reaffirm love so the person is not swallowed by excessive grief and Satan does not turn discipline into permanent alienation.

2. CORE New covenant ministry gives life

Paul does not need impressive letters of recommendation. The Corinthians themselves are a letter from Christ, written not with ink but by the Spirit, not merely on stone but on human hearts (3:1-3). His confidence is not self-confidence: God makes servants competent for the new covenant.

OLD COVENANT IMAGE	NEW COVENANT FULFILLMENT
Commandments written on stone	The Spirit writes God's will on human hearts (Jeremiah 31:31-34; Ezekiel 36:26-27).
The holy law exposes sin and condemns the disobedient	The Spirit gives life, righteousness, freedom, and power for transformation.
Moses' face reflected genuine but fading glory	The ministry of the Spirit has surpassing and enduring glory.
A veil represents hardened understanding	The veil is removed when a person turns to the Lord in Christ.
External command cannot change the heart	Believers behold the Lord's glory and are transformed into his image.

'The letter kills' does not mean that Scripture, careful reading, or the Old Testament is bad. The law is holy and its giving was glorious. But commandments written outside us cannot cure a rebellious heart or supply the power to obey; they expose sin and pronounce condemnation. The Spirit gives the life and inward renewal promised by the new covenant. The contrast is shadow and fulfillment, condemnation and righteousness, external command and Spirit-created transformation.

AVOID ANTI JEWISH CONCLUSIONS Paul is a Jewish apostle interpreting Israel's Scriptures, not contrasting a bad Jewish religion with a good Gentile religion. The old covenant had real divine glory and served God's purpose. The veil describes hardened response to God's word, a condition only Christ can remove and one that gives Gentile Christians no ground for boasting.

3. CORE Treasure in jars of clay

Read 4:7-12 and 16-18. The treasure is the gospel knowledge of God's glory in the face of Jesus Christ. The clay jars are ordinary, fragile messengers. God does not wait for flawless containers. Their weakness prevents anyone from confusing the vessel with the treasure and shows that the extraordinary power belongs to God.

PAUL'S EXPERIENCE	GOD'S SUSTAINING POWER
Hard pressed	Not crushed
Perplexed	Not in despair
Persecuted	Not abandoned
Struck down	Not destroyed
Carrying the death of Jesus	The life of Jesus becomes visible in mortal servants

Paul does not say faithful servants avoid suffering. He says affliction does not mean abandonment. The pattern of Jesus - death giving way to resurrection life - shapes Christian ministry. Paul can therefore say that death is at work in him while life is at work in those he serves.

'Our light and momentary troubles' must not be used to minimize another person's pain. Paul's own sufferings were severe. He calls them light only by comparison with the eternal weight of glory God is preparing. The outer person wastes away, the inner person is renewed, and faith fixes its attention on God's unseen and lasting future. Therefore, Paul does not lose heart.

4. CORE Resurrection hope produces courageous accountability

In 5:1-10, the earthly tent is the present mortal body: temporary, fragile, and subject to death. The building from God is best understood as the permanent resurrection body. Paul does not long to become less embodied; he longs to be further clothed so that mortality is swallowed up by life, continuing the bodily hope of 1 Corinthians 15.

Being unclothed describes the disembodied condition between death and resurrection, a real but incomplete state Paul does not prefer. Verse 8 nevertheless gives confidence that believers who die are away from the body and at home with the Lord. Teach both truths: believers are consciously with Christ after death, and their ultimate hope is not disembodied heaven but resurrection life. The Spirit is God's deposit guaranteeing that future.

THE JUDGMENT SEAT OF CHRIST Every believer will give an account for life and service. Paul is not undoing justification by grace or teaching that faithful Christians may finally be rejected by Christ. He is teaching real evaluation of deeds, motives, and stewardship. Grace removes condemnation; it does not make obedience unimportant. The prospect produces reverent responsibility and the aim of pleasing Christ.

5. CORE God entrusts reconciliation to fragile ambassadors

Read 5:14-21. Christ's love compels Paul because Christ died and was raised so that his people would no longer live for themselves. In Christ, the old order has passed and new creation has begun. God reconciles enemies to himself through Christ, does not count their sins against them, and entrusts the message of reconciliation to human ambassadors.

When Paul says that God made the sinless Christ 'to be sin for us,' he means that Christ bore sin and its judgment on behalf of sinners. United to Christ, believers receive right standing with God and become participants in God's reconciling work. An ambassador does not invent the message, promote himself, or coerce reconciliation. He represents the King and appeals: be reconciled to God.

6. CORE Open hearts without compromised allegiance

Paul pleads with the Corinthians to open their hearts to him (6:11-13; 7:2). That openness does not require openness to idolatry. In 6:14-7:1, the repeated contrasts - righteousness and wickedness, light and darkness, Christ and Belial, God's temple and idols - identify the central danger: participation that joins Christ's people to worship or conduct opposed to God.

The unequal yoke is broader than marriage, though marriage can be an instance because it is a binding union. Paul is not commanding isolation from unbelievers, forbidding friendship or evangelism, or dissolving existing mixed marriages (1 Corinthians 5:9-10; 7:12-16). He forbids partnerships and practices that require divided allegiance, shared idolatry, or compromise of Christian obedience.

CATEGORY	HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT
Contact and friendship	Necessary for love, neighborliness, work, and witness; not an unequal yoke by itself.

CATEGORY	HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT
Media and social media	Usually influence rather than a binding yoke. Ask what is shaping desire, normalizing sin, consuming attention, or weakening obedience.
Binding partnership	Shared ownership, authority, identity, vows, or obligations require careful judgment about whether faithfulness can be maintained.
Idolatrous participation	Worship, ritual, or conduct that gives another power the allegiance owed to God must be refused.

A television show or social-media account is not automatically the yoke Paul describes. It may still be foolish, spiritually deforming, or enslaving. Those questions are better tested by Christian freedom, holiness, conscience, and what builds up (1 Corinthians 6:12; 10:23-31), rather than forcing every media decision into this one metaphor.

Godly sorrow restores relationship

Paul regretted the pain caused by his severe letter but rejoiced that it produced repentance (7:8-16). Godly sorrow is not measured by emotional intensity or self-condemnation. Its fruit is a changed direction: earnestness, desire to make matters right, and renewed zeal. Worldly sorrow remains centered on embarrassment, damaged reputation, or consequences and can harden into despair. Gospel correction aims at repentance, restored trust, and joy.

The Gospel Then and Now

MOVEMENT	CHURCH APPLICATION
Church pressure then	Corinthians were tempted to judge ministry by impressive credentials, visible strength, and freedom from suffering.
Church temptation now	We can confuse polish, platform, growth, charisma, or constant success with the presence and power of God.
Gospel-shaped ministry	The Spirit transforms hearts, Christ's life appears in fragile servants, and reconciled people minister with integrity, endurance, holiness, and open hearts.

Discussion

1. What makes a ministry credible when visible success and faithfulness do not appear together?
2. Why does 'the letter kills' not mean that the Old Testament or careful biblical interpretation is harmful?
3. How does the image of treasure in jars of clay challenge Christian celebrity and platform culture?
4. How can Christ's judgment seat encourage responsibility without destroying assurance?
5. What does it mean for an ordinary Christian to serve as Christ's ambassador of reconciliation?
6. How can we distinguish ordinary contact, unhealthy influence, a binding yoke, and direct participation in idolatry?

Likely rabbit trails

The exact number and order of Paul's letters and visits; whether chapters 10-13 once circulated separately; identifying the offender; turning 'the letter kills' into a debate over literal interpretation; the exact nature of the intermediate state; ranking heavenly rewards; deciding whether every friendship, business relationship, political affiliation, movie, or social-media account is an unequal yoke; and resolving every atonement theory. Answer what is necessary, then return to Paul's claim: God's power is displayed through Spirit-transformed, weak, reconciling servants.

Leader preparation

Primary sources used in these notes: Life Application Bible Commentary New Testament, sections on 2 Corinthians 3 and 6-7; ESV Study Bible, notes on 2 Corinthians 3:6-18; and John Calvin, Commentary on 2 Corinthians 6:14. Biblical background: Exodus 34:29-35; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Ezekiel 36:26-27.

ECO connection: Essential Tenet II.B, the incarnation and saving work of Christ; III.C, covenant life in the church; and III.D, faithful stewardship of all of life. Official text: eco-pres.org/constitution/ Before Lesson 14: Read 2 Corinthians 8-13. Mark what Paul teaches about generosity, spiritual authority, boasting, weakness, and the sufficiency of Christ's grace.